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Driver & Vehicle Licensing Agency

Guidance

Converting a vehicle into a motor caravan (motor home)

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This publication is available at https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/converting-a-vehicle-into-a-motor-caravan/converting-a-vehicle-into-a-motor-caravan

DVLA is required to record vehicle details for road safety and law enforcement. The DVLA body type is used for establishing vehicle appearance and identification and should not affect the insurance category of the vehicle nor have any effect on speed limits or legislative requirements. To change the body type of a vehicle, DVLA must be satisfied that the vehicle meets their policy for body types, which is that the body type information held on the vehicle record must describe what a vehicle looks like in traffic.

It is important to remember that even if the vehicle's body type is not changed to 'motor caravan', the vehicle can still be used for this purpose as long as the keeper is satisfied the converted vehicle meets the required internal features for motor caravans (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/registering-a-diy-caravan).

It is the responsibility of the vehicle keeper to make sure that any alterations made to the vehicle do not compromise its safety. If you sell the vehicle at a later date, it is your responsibility as the registered keeper to demonstrate the conversion work has been safely completed.

Requirements for changing body type to motor caravan

DVLA will only consider changing the body type to 'motor caravan' (motor home) if the vehicle can meet the internal and external features listed below.

While DVLA will consider all applications for a change to body type, there will be certain vehicles with an original frame or outer structure that is so distinctive in appearance that the body type description cannot be changed from the initial manufactured design, for example, a bus. If you've previously applied to convert your vehicle to a motor home or motor caravan and your application was rejected, you can ask DVLA to review your application (https://www.gov.uk/guidance/ask-dvla-to-review-a-rejected-motorhome-body-type-application).

Motor caravan external permanent features

This list describes the external features which are commonly seen in motor caravans, and it is intended to provide guidance on what DVLA expects to see when considering your application:

- 2 or more windows on at least one side of the main body (this does not include windows on the driver or passenger doors) to provide a reasonable amount of daylight into the living accommodation
- a separate door which provides access to the living accommodation of the vehicle (this excludes the driver and passenger doors); a window on this door counts as a separate window on the main body
- a high-top roof or pop-top elevating roof

DVLA will need photographic evidence of the completed conversion.

Evidence needed to support your application

DVLA will need photographic evidence of the completed conversion. You must provide clear evidence that what you have made is permanently a 'motor caravan' and that the furniture and fixings have been fitted to a satisfactory standard.

You must include the following evidence to support your application:

- a completed motor caravan conversion checklist (https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/840319/v1006-motor-caravan-conversion-checklist.pdf)
- interior photos of each one of the required features with the bed and table in the use position (see 'Motor caravan internal features' (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/converting-a-vehicle-into-a-motor-caravan/converting-a-vehicle-into-a-motor-caravan#motor-caravan-internal-features) below); the photos must show that there are 2 or more windows providing daylight into the main living accommodation on at least one side of the main body
- exterior photos from the front, both sides and rear with the registration plates clearly visible
- a photo showing the vehicle identification number (VIN) or the chassis number stamped on the plate attached to the original chassis or vehicle bodyshell

On the back of each photo, write a description of what the photo shows, the date and the vehicle registration number.

Photographs will not be automatically returned. If you want your photographs returned, you must request this in your application.

If you have a new style V5C with multi-coloured numbered blocks on the front cover, fill in section 1.

If you have the older style V5C, fill in section 7.

Make any other changes, if you need to, and send the V5C with the required evidence to:

> DVLA
> Swansea
> SA99 1BA

DVLA will consider all the information provided. They will then either decide that the body type must stay the same, or allocate an appropriate description based on the changes made to make sure the recorded body type accurately reflects the vehicle's external appearance in traffic.

Your vehicle may also require a DVLA inspection. DVLA will cover the cost of the inspection, but any costs associated with transporting the vehicle to the inspection will not be reimbursed. If the vehicle cannot be inspected, the application will be refused and no further action will be taken.

When converting a van or other vehicle to a motor caravan, it is important to ensure safety and use a reputable converter. Any seat belts and seats installed, that are for use while travelling, must be securely mounted. The weight of installed equipment will increase the unladen weight, which will decrease the payload. The converted vehicle should have sufficient payload (unladen weight subtracted from gross vehicle weight) to carry as many passengers as it has seats for, as well as luggage and full water tanks, for example, without being overloaded.

Motor caravan internal features

The following shows the internal features which are seen in special purpose M category vehicles, constructed to include living accommodation:

- seats and a table
- sleeping accommodation, which may be converted from the seats
- cooking facilities
- storage facilities

This equipment must be rigidly fixed to the living compartment, however, the table may be designed to be easily removable.

These features are defined by the type approval requirements for motor caravans.

See the full definition for required internal features (https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/registering-a-diy-caravan).

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